



“Until now I have never really lived! ... It is in the air that one feels the glory of being a man and of conquering the elements. There is an exquisite smoothness of motion and the joy of gliding through space.”

GABRIELE D'ANNUNZIO

ITALIAN POET AND NOVELIST, 1909

FLYING TAKES OFF

FROM 1909 TO 1914, AVIATION DEVELOPED FROM AN OBJECT OF CURIOSITY INTO A MODERN CRAZE THAT GRIPPED THE POPULAR IMAGINATION

THE BEGINNING OF this new phase in the conquest of the air was symbolized by two events in the summer of 1909: Blériot's flight across the English Channel, and the Reims aviation meeting.

In July 1909, the attention of the world's media was focused on the cliffs of Sangatte, outside Calais, on the north coast of France. From there, on a rare clear day, you can see across to the white cliffs of Dover on the other side of the English Channel. This narrow strip of water, which had been of such historic importance in separating the British from continental Europe, was about to be crossed by a flying machine.

This was an event that had been created for the newspaper-reading public. Lord Northcliffe, owner of the *Daily Mail*, was a firm believer in the need for newspapers to create news, rather than just report it. He was also an enthusiastic believer in the future of aviation. In the wake of the sensation caused by Wilbur Wright's flights in Europe in 1908, Northcliffe had put up a prize of £500 (later raised to £1,000 [\$4,850]) for the first man to fly across the Channel. The challenge captured the public imagination and other newspapers from across Europe



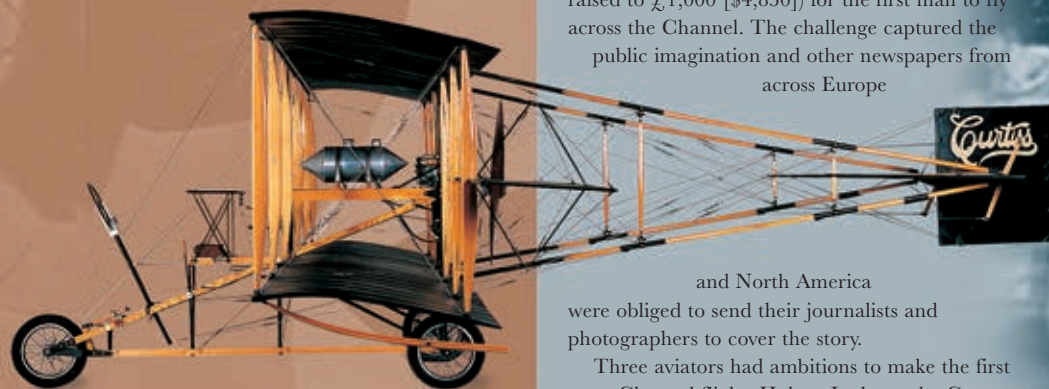
MAN OF THE WORLD

Hubert Latham was a wealthy playboy who raced automobiles and speedboats in France before turning his attention to airplanes in September 1909. A month later, he won the altitude prize at the Grande Semaine de L'Aviation de la Champagne, flying an Antoinette IV.

and North America

were obliged to send their journalists and photographers to cover the story.

Three aviators had ambitions to make the first cross-Channel flight: Hubert Latham, the Comte de Lambert, and Louis Blériot. The Comte de Lambert had been taught to fly by Wilbur Wright and was the owner of two Wright biplanes. Latham and Blériot were equipped with new monoplanes, of a very different configuration



HEADLESS FLYING MACHINE

A favorite of stunt fliers like Lincoln Beachey, this 1910 Curtiss Model D headless pusher had several remarkable features. Easy to assemble for shipment or repairs, it had bamboo tail-struts, which were light and splinter-resistant. Fast for its day, it won numerous prizes at flying meetings.

